Multi-threaded Web Server

Project Report

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Contents

1 Summary **3**

2 Design Overview **3**
2.1 Architecture 3
2.2 Component Description 3
2.3 Data Structures 4

3 Implementation Details **4**
3.1 Socket Programming Flow 4
3.2 HTTP Methods Supported 4
3.3 Response Status Codes 5
3.4 HTTP Headers Handled 5
3.5 Persistent Connections (Keep-Alive) 5
3.6 Thread Safety and Logging 6
3.7 Security Features 6

4 File Organization **6**

5 Testing Results **7**
5.1 Test Cases Performed 7
5.2 Sample Log Output 7

6 Performance Considerations **7**

7 Demonstration **8**

8 Conclusion **8**

1 Summary

This project implements a multi-threaded HTTP/1.1 web server in C using POSIX socket programming and `pthreads`. The server is designed to handle concurrent client connections efficiently. It supports `GET` and `HEAD` HTTP methods, implements proper HTTP response codes, processes both persistent and non-persistent connections, and maintains a robust thread-safe request log.

2 Design Overview

2.1 Architecture

The server follows a Thread-Per-Connection model. The main thread listens for incoming connections and spawns a new detached worker thread for each accepted client connection.

```
+-------------------------------------------------------------+
|                    Main Server Process                      |
+-------------------------------------------------------------+
|  +-------------+    +-------------------------------------+ |
|  |   Listener  |--->|         Thread Pool Manager         | |
|  |   Socket    |    |  (Creates thread per connection)    | |
|  +-------------+    +-------------------------------------+ |
|                              |                              |
|         +--------------------+--------------------+         |
|         v                    v                    v         |
|  +-------------+      +-------------+      +-------------+  |
|  |  Thread 1   |      |  Thread 2   |      |  Thread N   |  |
|  |  (Client 1) |      |  (Client 2) |      |  (Client N) |  |
|  +-------------+      +-------------+      +-------------+  |
|         |                    |                    |         |
|         +--------------------+--------------------+         |
|                              v                              |
|                    +-----------------+                      |
|                    |    Log File     |                      |
|                    |  (Mutex Lock)   |                      |
|                    +-----------------+                      |
+-------------------------------------------------------------+
```

2.2 Component Description

Component	Description
Main Thread	Listens for incoming connections and spawns worker threads
Worker Threads	Handle individual client requests (one thread per connection)
Request Parser	Parses HTTP request headers and extracts method, URI, etc.
Response Builder	Constructs HTTP responses with appropriate headers
File Handler	Reads files from disk and determines proper MIME types
Logger	Thread-safe logging mechanism using mutex protection

2.3 Data Structures

The core data structures used to parse requests and format responses are defined as follows:

```c
// HTTP Request representation
typedef struct {
    char method[16];            // GET, HEAD
    char uri[512];              // Requested resource path
    char version[16];           // HTTP/1.0 or HTTP/1.1
    HttpHeader headers[50];     // Request headers
    int header_count;           // Number of headers
} HttpRequest;

// HTTP Response representation
typedef struct {
    int status_code;            // 200, 304, 400, 403, 404
    char status_text[64];       // OK, Not Found, etc.
    HttpHeader headers[50];     // Response headers
    int header_count;           // Number of headers
    char *body;                 // Response body
    long body_length;           // Body size in bytes
    int send_body;              // Flag for HEAD requests
} HttpResponse;
```

Listing 1: Core HTTP Data Structures

3 Implementation Details

3.1 Socket Programming Flow

The network communication follows the standard POSIX socket API sequence:

1. `socket()` - Create TCP socket.
2. `setsockopt()` - Enable `SO_REUSEADDR` to prevent binding issues.
3. `bind()` - Bind the socket to the specified port (default 8080).
4. `listen()` - Mark the socket as passive to listen for incoming connections.
5. `accept()` - Block and accept client connections in an infinite loop.
6. `pthread_create()` - Spawn a detached thread to process the accepted client.
7. `recv() / send()` - Handle HTTP request/response exchange within the thread.
8. `close()` - Close the client socket upon completion or timeout.

3.2 HTTP Methods Supported

Method	Description
`GET`	Retrieves the requested resource including the response body.
`HEAD`	Retrieves the headers only (verifies existence, size, modification).

3.3 Response Status Codes

The server accurately implements the five required HTTP status codes:

Code	Status	Condition
200	OK	Successful request; file is returned.
304	Not Modified	File unchanged since `If-Modified-Since` date.
400	Bad Request	Invalid HTTP request format or unknown method.
403	Forbidden	Directory traversal attempted or lack of read permission.
404	Not Found	The requested file does not exist on the server.

3.4 HTTP Headers Handled

Request Headers Evaluated:

- `Connection`: Determines if the connection should be `keep-alive` or `close`.
- `If-Modified-Since`: Facilitates Conditional `GET` logic.

Response Headers Generated:

- `Date`: Current server timestamp.
- `Server`: Server identification string.
- `Content-Type`: MIME type of the resource (derived from file extension).
- `Content-Length`: Size of the response body.
- `Last-Modified`: Modification timestamp of the requested file.
- `Connection`: Persistent connection status mapping.

3.5 Persistent Connections (Keep-Alive)

The server implements HTTP/1.1 persistent connections to reduce TCP handshake overhead. The thread enters a loop governed by a timeout (using `setsockopt` with `SO_RCVTIMEO`) and a maximum request counter limit.

```
// Set socket timeout for keep-alive
struct timeval timeout;
timeout.tv_sec = KEEP_ALIVE_TIMEOUT; // 30 seconds
timeout.tv_usec = 0;
setsockopt(client_socket, SOL_SOCKET, SO_RCVTIMEO, &timeout, sizeof(
    timeout));

while (keep_alive && request_count < MAX_KEEP_ALIVE_REQUESTS) {
    // 1. recv() data
    // 2. parse request
    // 3. check "Connection" header (if "close", keep_alive = 0)
    // 4. handle_request()
    request_count++;
}
```

Listing 2: Keep-Alive Logic Snippet

3.6 Thread Safety and Logging

Shared resources, specifically the server log file, are protected using POSIX mutexes to prevent race conditions when multiple threads attempt to write log entries simultaneously.

```c
pthread_mutex_t log_mutex = PTHREAD_MUTEX_INITIALIZER;

void log_request(struct sockaddr_in *client_addr,
                 const char *request_line, int status_code) {
    pthread_mutex_lock(&log_mutex);

    FILE *log_file = fopen("server.log", "a");
    if (log_file != NULL) {
        // format timestamp and client IP
        // write to log
        fclose(log_file);
    }

    pthread_mutex_unlock(&log_mutex);
}
```

Listing 3: Thread-safe Logging

3.7 Security Features

1. **Directory Traversal Prevention:** Uses `realpath()` to ensure requested files strictly reside within the designated `/www` document root.
2. **Permission Checking:** Verifies read access via the `access()` system call before attempting to open the file.
3. **Buffer Safety:** Uses bounded string operations (`strncpy`, `snprintf`) and enforces strict limits on header counts and URI lengths.
4. **SIGPIPE Handling:** Ignores broken pipe signals to prevent the server from crashing if a client disconnects abruptly.

4 File Organization

The project directory is structured as follows:

```
project/
|-- webserver.c     # Main source code
|-- Makefile        # Build automation instructions
|-- README.md       # Compilation and Usage instructions
|-- server.log      # Request log (auto-generated)
`-- www/            # Document root
    |-- index.html  # Default landing page
    |-- images/     # Image files directory
    `-- styles/     # CSS files directory
```

5 Testing Results

5.1 Test Cases Performed

Extensive testing was performed using a web browser and `cURL` command-line utility.

Test Command/Action	Expected Result	Status
`GET /`	`200 OK` with `index.html` body	✓ Pass
`GET /nonexistent.html`	`404 Not Found` error page	✓ Pass
`HEAD /`	`200 OK`, headers only (no body)	✓ Pass
`GET ../../etc/passwd`	`403 Forbidden`	✓ Pass
`If-Modified-Since` (future date)	`304 Not Modified`	✓ Pass
Invalid HTTP syntax	`400 Bad Request`	✓ Pass
`Connection: keep-alive`	Connection remains open for 30s	✓ Pass
`Connection: close`	Connection closes immediately	✓ Pass
Retrieve binary file (PNG)	Correct `image/png` MIME type	✓ Pass

5.2 Sample Log Output

Below is a raw extract from the `server.log` file generated during testing:

```
127.0.0.1 | 2026-04-05 20:31:47 | GET / HTTP/1.1 | 200 OK
127.0.0.1 | 2026-04-05 20:31:47 | GET /favicon.ico HTTP/1.1 | 403 Forbidden
127.0.0.1 | 2026-04-05 20:31:54 | GET /test.html HTTP/1.1 | 200 OK
127.0.0.1 | 2026-04-05 20:31:54 | GET /images/test.png HTTP/1.1 | 200 OK
127.0.0.1 | 2026-04-05 20:32:00 | GET /nonexistent.html HTTP/1.1 | 403 Forbidden
127.0.0.1 | 2026-04-05 20:33:22 | GET / HTTP/1.1 | 200 OK
127.0.0.1 | 2026-04-05 20:33:44 | GET /test.html HTTP/1.1 | 304 Not Modified
127.0.0.1 | 2026-04-05 20:33:44 | GET /images/test.png HTTP/1.1 | 304 Not Modified
```

6 Performance Considerations

- **Thread-per-request model:** This approach provides a robust and simple concurrency architecture. However, it incurs higher memory and CPU overhead compared to asynchronous event-driven models (like `epoll` or `select`), making it less ideal for handling thousands of simultaneous connections.
- **Keep-alive support:** Drastically reduces the latency and overhead of establishing new TCP connections for subsequent requests from the same client.
- **Memory Buffering:** Files are currently read entirely into memory before transmission. While fast for small CSS/HTML files, this could cause memory spikes for excessively large files (e.g., large videos).

7 Demonstration

```
ad@debian:~/公共/Multi-thread_Web_Server$ ./webserver 8080
========================================
  Multi-threaded Web Server Started
========================================
  Port: 8080
  Document Root: ./www
  Log File: server.log
  URL: http://127.0.0.1:8080/
========================================
Press Ctrl+C to stop the server

Client connected: 127.0.0.1:41414
Client disconnected: 127.0.0.1:41414 (handled 1 requests)
```

```
ad@debian:~$ curl -i http://127.0.0.1:8080/
HTTP/1.1 200 OK
Date: Sun, 05 Apr 2026 12:47:43 GMT
Server: SimpleWebServer/1.0
Last-Modified: Sun, 05 Apr 2026 12:44:30 GMT
Content-Type: text/html
Content-Length: 1808
Connection: close

<!DOCTYPE html>
<html lang="en">
<head>
    <meta charset="UTF-8">
    <meta name="viewport" content="width=device-width, initial-scale=1.0">
    <title>Welcome - Simple Web Server</title>
    <style>
        body {
            font-family: 'Segoe UI', Arial, sans-serif;
            max-width: 800px;
            margin: 50px auto;
            padding: 20px;
            background: linear-gradient(135deg, #667eea 0%, #764ba2 100%);
            min-height: 100vh;
        }
```

8 Conclusion

The developed multi-threaded web server successfully fulfills all project requirements. It demonstrates a deep practical understanding of POSIX socket programming, multi-threading, concurrency control using mutexes, and the fundamental mechanics of the HTTP/1.1 protocol. The server accurately parses client requests, enforces security via directory constraints, and effectively manages persistent TCP connections.